

CUSTOMER SUCCESS MANAGER

Training And Operating Policy

Fictional company policy for role-based training and assessment

Policy Owner	Vice President, Customer Operations
Effective Date	August 1, 2026
Review Cycle	Every 12 months, or within 30 days of a material process change
Applies To	All Customer Success Managers and temporary CSM coverage staff

Policy Purpose

This policy defines the minimum operating standards for a Customer Success Manager at Meridian Client Services, a fictional business-to-business subscription services company. The CSM owns post-sale adoption, relationship management, risk identification, renewal readiness, escalation coordination, and customer record quality. Sales owns commercial negotiation, Support owns technical troubleshooting, Finance owns invoicing and credits, and Legal owns contract interpretation. A CSM may coordinate those functions but must not replace their approval authority.

Customer Onboarding Control

A CSM becomes the operational owner of a new account when the signed order form is marked "Booked" in the CRM and the implementation handoff record is complete. Within 1 business day, the CSM must review the contract term, annual contract value, purchased services, named executive sponsor, billing start date, and any success criteria promised during the sale. The first customer-facing kickoff must occur within 5 business days of booking unless the customer requests a later date in writing. Before that meeting, the CSM must send a kickoff agenda at least 24 hours in advance and confirm that the customer has named one day-to-day administrator and one business sponsor. An onboarding record is considered complete only when the target go-live date, first-value milestone, stakeholder list, meeting cadence, and measurable 90-day outcome are entered in the CRM.

For standard accounts under \$100,000 in annual contract value, the default onboarding period is 45 calendar days; accounts at or above \$100,000 receive a 60-day target unless Implementation approves a different plan. The CSM is responsible for tracking customer-owned actions and for escalating missed dependencies. If a customer task is 5 business days overdue, the CSM sends a written reminder and records the blocker. At 10 business days overdue, the CSM must notify the customer sponsor and the internal Implementation Manager. At 15 business days overdue, the account is marked "Onboarding At Risk" and the CSM schedules a recovery meeting within 3 business days. Correct onboarding does not mean every feature is used; it means the agreed first-value milestone has been achieved, the customer confirms that outcome in writing, and no critical dependency remains unassigned.

Account Health Reviews

Every managed account must have a health score refreshed at least once every 14 calendar days. Meridian uses four health categories: Green, Yellow, Red, and Executive Watch. A Green account has no unresolved severity-one issue, at least 75% of the agreed monthly usage target, no invoice more than 30 days past due, and an identified sponsor who has engaged within the last 90 days. A Yellow account has one material risk, such as usage between 50% and 74% of target, a sponsor inactive for 91 to 120 days, two missed recurring

meetings, or an unresolved support issue older than 10 business days. A Red account has usage below 50% of target, a written cancellation threat, an invoice more than 60 days past due, a severity-one issue unresolved for more than 24 hours, or no reachable sponsor for more than 120 days.

The CSM must create a written recovery plan for every Red account within 2 business days of the status change. The plan must name the risk, the desired customer outcome, the internal owner, the customer owner, the next action, and a dated checkpoint no more than 10 business days away. Executive Watch is not a substitute for Red; it is an additional flag applied by the VP of Customer Operations to accounts with annual contract value of at least \$250,000, reputational risk, or a credible legal or executive complaint. Green accounts require a documented value review at least quarterly, Yellow accounts require a customer touchpoint at least every 30 days, and Red accounts require a live customer touchpoint at least every 10 business days until the risk is resolved. A status may return to Green only after the triggering condition has been absent for 14 consecutive days.

Customer Communication Standards

All customer email and meeting commitments must be recorded in the CRM when they create an obligation, deadline, commercial expectation, or escalation. A CSM must acknowledge direct customer messages within 1 business day, even when a full answer is not yet available. If a request requires another department, the acknowledgment must identify the internal owner and state when the next update will be provided; that update date may not be more than 3 business days away. Meeting notes must be entered within 1 business day and must include decisions, action owners, due dates, and any change in customer sentiment. Statements such as “we will look into it” are not sufficient records because they do not identify ownership or timing.

CSMs may explain existing product behavior, published service levels, and approved roadmaps, but they may not promise an unreleased capability, guaranteed delivery date, contract exception, refund, service credit, or pricing concession. When a customer asks for a future feature, the CSM records the use case and business impact and routes the request to Product through the approved feedback form within 2 business days. The CSM may tell the customer that the request was submitted, but may not say it is “committed,” “scheduled,” or “guaranteed” unless Product has issued an approved customer-facing statement. Correct communication separates confirmed facts from requests under review and gives the customer a specific next-update date whenever an answer remains pending.

Escalation And Incident Handling

A customer issue becomes a formal escalation when it meets any one of four conditions: a severity-one service incident, a written threat to cancel or involve counsel, an executive complaint sent to a Meridian vice president or higher, or a business-impacting issue that has missed two agreed recovery dates. The CSM must open an escalation record within 30 minutes for a severity-one incident and within 4 business hours for all other escalation triggers. Support owns incident diagnosis and restoration, while the CSM owns customer communication, stakeholder coordination, and the accuracy of the business-impact statement. For severity-one incidents, the first customer update is due within 30 minutes of confirmation and subsequent updates are due at least every 60 minutes until service is restored or Support formally downgrades severity.

The CSM must notify the Customer Success Director when an escalation affects an account worth \$100,000 or more annually, when a customer executive is involved, or when the issue remains open longer than 1 business day. The VP of Customer Operations must be notified when annual contract value is at least \$250,000, when legal action is threatened, when public or press exposure is mentioned, or when a severity-one incident exceeds 4 hours. After resolution, the CSM schedules a customer closeout within 5 business days and records whether the customer accepted the resolution. If the incident lasted more than 2 hours or caused a missed contractual service level, Support produces the root-cause summary and Finance determines any service credit. The CSM may present an approved credit but may not calculate or authorize one independently.

Renewals And Commercial Commitments

Renewal planning begins 120 calendar days before contract end for accounts with annual contract value of \$50,000 or more and 90 days before contract end for smaller accounts. At the start of the renewal window, the CSM must confirm current health, documented outcomes, open risks, stakeholder changes, adoption against target, and whether the customer has procurement or notice deadlines. By 90 days before expiration for larger accounts and 60 days for smaller accounts, the CSM must hold or schedule a value review that summarizes at least two measurable outcomes achieved during the term. If health is Red when the renewal window opens, the CSM must notify the Account Executive within 1 business day and provide the current recovery plan before any renewal proposal is sent.

Account Executives own pricing, term length, discounting, and contract language. A CSM may discuss value, usage, business goals, and expected renewal timing, but may not quote a price or agree to a concession unless the Account Executive has provided the exact approved terms in writing. Discounts above 10% require Sales Director approval, discounts above 20% require the VP of Sales, and any free service period longer than 30 days requires both VP of Sales and Finance approval. A customer is not considered “renewed” because they verbally agree; renewal is complete only when the signed order form or approved purchase order is received and the CRM opportunity is marked Closed Won. If a customer states an intent not to renew, the CSM must record the reason within 1 business day using the standard churn-reason category and preserve the customer’s wording in the notes.

Data Handling And Recordkeeping

CSMs may access only customer information needed to manage the account and must use company-approved systems for storage. Customer contracts, contact data, support details, meeting notes, and business metrics belong in the CRM or approved document repository; they must not be stored in personal email, personal cloud drives, local desktop folders beyond temporary working copies, or consumer messaging applications. Temporary local files containing customer confidential information must be deleted within 24 hours after upload to the approved repository. If a customer sends credentials, payment card data, government identification, or other restricted information in an ordinary email, the CSM must not copy it into the CRM. The CSM must stop using the data, notify the Security and Privacy queue within 1 business hour, and follow the removal instructions provided by that team.

CRM records must be written so another CSM can assume the account without relying on private memory or private messages. At minimum, a customer interaction that changes account status must identify the date, participants, decision, owner, due date, and next checkpoint. The CSM must update stakeholder departures, new executive sponsors, renewal risks, and escalation outcomes within 1 business day of learning them. Records may not be deleted to improve account optics or remove evidence of a customer complaint. If an entry is materially wrong, the CSM corrects it using the CRM’s edit history and adds a note explaining the correction. Managers audit a random sample of 5 accounts per CSM each quarter; a record is compliant when all required fields are current, no material commitment is missing, and no restricted data is present.

Internal Use Notice

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